

Artist Prospecting System

Art Queens Gallery · Project summary for management · 26 July 2026

What this project is

We are building a system that finds professional female artists and works out how to contact them directly, so the gallery can invite them to paid international exhibitions in Paris, New York and Milan. Today that research is done by hand, one artist at a time. This system does it automatically and keeps the results, so the same work is never paid for twice.

The end product is not a one-off list. It is a growing, reusable database of qualified artists that becomes more valuable every time we run it.

Results delivered so far

Finished leads — female artist + her own verified email	117
Extra records delivered (websites, phone numbers, partial finds)	449
of those, with a phone number	368
Individual artists researched	591
Organisations opened up and searched	173
Organisations that actually produced leads	10

Of the 117 leads, 22 are high confidence and 95 are medium. Medium means the address is real, resolves correctly and was found on the artist's own page — usually a personal Gmail, which is normal for working artists. It does not mean the mailbox has been test-mailed, so some bounces should be expected on a first send.

What counts as one finished lead

A finished lead is one thing only: an artist's name plus a working email address that belongs to her personally. A gallery's shared address (*info@somegallery.com*) does not count, even though it is easy to find. If we email the gallery, our invitation goes to a receptionist. If we email the artist, it goes to the person who would actually travel and exhibit.

Phone numbers, websites and social handles are useful extras. They are collected and delivered, but they never make a lead count as finished.

What we started with

One Excel sheet listing **192 art-world organisations** — galleries, magazines, art prizes, museums and art fairs. These are not leads. They are *places where artists are displayed*. Each one had to be opened up to find the artists it presents. Of the 192, 19 had no website at all (Instagram only), leaving 173 we could actually work with.

How it works, in five steps

- **1. Look inside each organisation.** We read every page on its website and list which pages belong to individual artists. This is cheap, so we did it for all 173.
- **2. Test a few artists first.** For each organisation we check three artists to see whether they publish their own email, or whether the site only shows the gallery's shared address. This small test decides whether the organisation is worth pursuing at all.
- **3. Follow the trail for the artists worth following.** Artist's page → her own website → her contact page → her email address.
- **4. Check who the email really belongs to.** This is the hardest and most important part, explained overleaf.
- **5. Deliver two sheets.** One with finished leads ready to email, one with the extra information such as phone numbers.

The most important thing we learned

Success has almost nothing to do with how many artists an organisation lists. It depends on one thing: **whether that organisation's artists have their own websites.**

- Organisations that print one shared address on every artist's page produced **zero** leads — 86 artists researched, nothing usable.
- Organisations whose artists link to their own websites produced **all 117** leads.
- Out of 68 organisations tested, only **10** were of the useful kind. The other 58 were structurally incapable of ever producing an artist's personal email.

This is why step 2 matters so much commercially. Testing three artists costs almost nothing and tells us whether the remaining fifty are worth the spend. Without it, most of the budget goes into organisations that can never deliver.

A problem we found and fixed

Partway through, we discovered the system had been recording the *wrong* email addresses and counting them as wins — a cookie-consent supplier's help desk, a gallery's sales office, a magazine platform's support address. **114 of the first 140 records were affected.** Left alone, it would have produced a large list of addresses that reach nobody useful, and made the project look more successful than it was.

The fix came from a simple, reliable rule found in our own data: **an email address or website that turns up for more than one artist cannot belong to any single artist.** A real artist's website appears once. The false ones appeared 10, 17, even 42 times. The system now stops as soon as it sees a repeat, which both protects accuracy and cuts cost.

Every reported figure in this document is from after that correction. We deliberately report the smaller, true number.

Limits you should know about

- **The female-only check is done by a person, not the computer.** Names that could be either gender are excluded rather than guessed. This makes the list slightly shorter than it could be, but prevents an earlier embarrassment where two male artists reached the finished list.
- **A small number of addresses may still be wrong.** Three were caught by eye and removed. A spot-check before any large send is sensible.
- **Emails have not been test-mailed.** Doing so properly requires a paid verification service, which is a decision for later.

Where the build stands today

The full automated system is roughly half built. The permanent framework — the part that will not need rewriting — is finished and tested, with 564 automated checks that run every time the code changes. The pieces that connect it to live websites are still being written. Rather than wait for that, we ran the whole process semi-manually to prove the approach and to get usable leads into the gallery's hands now. It worked, and the 117 leads above are the result.

What happens next

About 900 artists inside the ten proven organisations are still unresearched. The expensive discovery work for them is already done and saved, so continuing is now much cheaper per lead than starting was: at the rate we measured, a further budget the same size as the one just spent would realistically add **150–200 more finished leads.**

Two decisions are worth taking when convenient. First, whether to pay for an email verification service, which would turn most of the medium-confidence leads into high confidence and cut bounces. Second, whether to prioritise finishing the automated system, which would stop this being a manual exercise and make it something the team can run on its own.

Two files accompany this summary. COMPLETED_LEADS — the 117 finished leads, ready to email. **ENRICHMENT (not a must)** — 449 further records including 368 phone numbers, useful for research and follow-up but not counted as finished leads.